‘beef cannot be the only point of reference when it comes to the North East’. He said that it was taking attention away from ‘real issues’, and that there was no cultural issue or gap ‘between us and BJP’, and gave assurances that ‘even on the issue of beef’, the Centre had already said that ‘there would be consultations’.[49]

This strategic adaptability is most evident in the fact that some long-time RSS workers actually changed their dietary habits while working with tribes in the Northeast. Sunil Deodhar, a key BJP strategist who is regarded as the architect of the party’s election triumph in Tripura, told the journalist Sanjib Baruah that he found ‘gahori [pork in Assamese and Nagamese] very delicious’ and that it was one of his ‘favourite foods’. A Chitpavan Brahmin from Maharashtra, Deodhar said he had ‘reservations on beef’ but had eaten ‘wild rats in Meghalaya’, quoting a Sanskrit shloka, ‘*Yasmin deshe hi yo jate: tazz tasvoyaya hitam* [The medicines of a country are the best cure for ailments in that country]’. Another former RSS man, Atul Jog, a top ABVKA functionary, said he ate ‘pork and rice beer, whatever we are offered’. He offered a telling comment to explain the diet change: ‘*Jaisa desh vaisa bhesh* [Take the form of the country you are in].’ Like Deodhar, Jog too drew the line at beef, saying, ‘We don’t consume beef and the tribes know it. We refuse with respect and they acknowledge it … But now even they are realising the importance of, utility and significance of raising cows—something that they have also started. Take, for example, in the Tangsa community in Arunachal Pradesh, there is a group called Raangfra, which is trying to encourage vegetarianism.’[50] Deodhar, who started wearing the ethnic scarf worn by some tribes in Tripura after he arrived there, told another reporter that he started eating pork only after moving to the state. He said it was not easy to make dietary changes, but that he did so to start building a base for the party in the state. He also learnt Bengali, a major language there, and engaged a tutor to learn tribal languages.[51] According to one account, between them, Deodhar and Jog, both of whom have worked in the Northeast for at least a decade each, ‘speak a variety of languages and dialects like Assamese, Khasi, Jaintia, Angami, Naga, Manipuri etc’.[52]